“Śrī Caitanya-caritāmṛta”

Ādi-līlā

Chapter 8

The Order of the Vaiṣṇavas

(translated from the Bengali for this edition)

1 I offer obeisance to Śrī Caitanya-deva, the Supreme Lord, by whose will even this fool is forcibly made to dance so wonderfully on the stage of writing.

2 All glory, all glory to Śrī Kṛṣṇa Caitanya Gauracandra! All glory to Him who is supreme bliss, glory to Nityānanda!

3 Glory, glory to the all-merciful Advaita Ācārya! Glory, glory to the noble-hearted Gadādhara Paṇḍita!

4 Glory, glory to all the devotees headed by Śrīvāsa! Bowing low, I worship the feet of them all.

5 By remembering Them, the mute compose poetry, the lame cross mountains and the blind see the stars.

6 Those scholars who do not accept all this — their study of learning is only the croaking of frogs.

7 Whoever does not accept all this, even though he practices devotion to Kṛṣṇa, does not receive Kṛṣṇa's mercy and reaches no goal.

8 Formerly kings such as Jarāsandha followed the Vedic religion and worshiped Viṣṇu,

9 but they did not accept Kṛṣṇa, and so we regard them as demons (*daityas*). In the same way, we know that one who does not accept Śrī Caitanya is a demon.

10 “If people do not accept Me, they will all be ruined.” For this reason the Lord, His heart melting with mercy, accepted *sannyāsa*.

11 “Thinking Me a *sannyāsī*, they will offer Me obeisance; even so, their suffering will be cut off and they will attain deliverance.”

12 A person who does not worship so merciful a Caitanya is counted among the demons (*asuras*), even if he is the best of men.

13 Therefore, with arms raised, I say again: give up false argument and worship Caitanya and Nityānanda!

14 Or if a logician says, “Logic is the proof; whatever is established by the science of logic, that alone is worthy of worship,”

15 then consider the mercy of Śrī Kṛṣṇa Caitanya. If you consider it, your heart will be struck with wonder.

16 One may hear and chant for many births and still not attain the treasure of love (*prema*) for Kṛṣṇa's feet.

17 “Liberation is easily attained through knowledge, and enjoyment through sacrifices and other pious acts; but devotion to Hari is extremely rare, even after thousands of spiritual practices.” (Tantra; also Bhakti-rasāmṛta-sindhu 1.1.36)

18 Kṛṣṇa may slip away by giving a devotee enjoyment or liberation, but devotion He does not readily give; He keeps it hidden.

19 “O king, the Lord Mukunda is the master, guru, worshipable Deity, beloved friend and head of the family for you and the Yadus, and sometimes He is even your servant. Be that as it may, my dear king, to those who worship Him the Lord sometimes grants liberation, but not *bhakti-yoga*.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam 5.6.18)

20 Such love Śrī Caitanya gave everywhere, even to Jagāi and Mādhāi — what to speak of others!

21 The independent Lord distributed love, that hidden treasure, to anyone and everyone without discrimination.

22 See how even today whoever takes Caitanya's name is overwhelmed with love for Kṛṣṇa, his hair standing on end and tears flowing.

23 When one says “Nityānanda,” love for Kṛṣṇa awakens; all one's limbs are shaken, and a Gaṅgā of tears flows.

24 The name of Kṛṣṇa takes offenses into account: when an offender says “Kṛṣṇa,” no transformation takes place in him.

25 “Alas, that heart is as hard as stone which does not melt when it takes up the names of Hari; for when it does melt, tears fill the eyes and the hairs of the body stand on end with joy.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam 2.3.24)

26 A single name of Kṛṣṇa destroys all sins and manifests devotion, the cause of love.

27 When love arises, love's transformations appear: perspiration, trembling, hair standing on end, a choked voice and streams of tears.

28 Worldly existence ends without effort, and one gains service to Kṛṣṇa: such wealth one obtains as the fruit of a single name of Kṛṣṇa.

29–30 If one chants such a name of Kṛṣṇa many times and still love does not appear and tears do not flow, then I know that his offenses are many, and the seed of Kṛṣṇa's name does not sprout in him.

31 With Caitanya and Nityānanda there are no such considerations. When one takes Their names, They give love, and tears flow.

32 The Lord is the independent Supreme Lord and supremely magnanimous. Without worshiping Him one is never delivered.

33 O foolish people, hear the *Caitanya-maṅgala* (the *Caitanya-bhāgavata*), in which you will come to know all of Śrī Caitanya's glory.

34 Veda-vyāsa tells Kṛṣṇa's pastimes in the *Bhāgavatam*; the Vyāsa of Śrī Caitanya's pastimes is Vṛndāvana dāsa.

35 Vṛndāvana dāsa composed the *Caitanya-maṅgala*; by hearing it, all that is inauspicious is destroyed.

36 From it we learn the glory of Caitanya and Nitāi, and from it we learn the farthest reach of the conclusions of devotion to Kṛṣṇa.

37 All the essence of the conclusions of devotion in the *Bhāgavatam* he has written down in it, drawing it out with full understanding.

38 If even an unbeliever (*pāṣaṇḍī*) or a *yavana* hears the *Caitanya-maṅgala*, he at once becomes a great Vaiṣṇava.

39 No human being could compose such a blessed book: the speaker, through the mouth of Vṛndāvana dāsa, is Śrī Caitanya Himself.

40 Millions of obeisances at the feet of Vṛndāvana dāsa! By writing such a book he has delivered the world.

41 Nārāyaṇī received the remnants of Śrī Caitanya's food, and from her womb Śrī Vṛndāvana dāsa was born.

42 How wonderful is his description of Śrī Caitanya's life! Hearing it has purified the three worlds.

43 Therefore, O people, worship Caitanya and Nityānanda! The sufferings of worldly existence will be cut off, and you will attain the bliss of love.

44 Vṛndāvana dāsa composed the *Caitanya-maṅgala*, and in it he described all of Śrī Caitanya's pastimes.

45 First he arranged all the pastimes in brief, as threads (*sūtra*); afterwards he described them in detail.

46 The pastimes of Caitanya-candra are endless and boundless; as he went on describing them, the book grew long.

47 Seeing its length, he felt some hesitation, and some pastimes included in the summary he did not describe.

48 He became absorbed in describing Nityānanda's pastimes, and Śrī Caitanya's final pastimes were left untold.

49 The devotees living in Vṛndāvana longed to hear a description of all those pastimes.

50 In Vṛndāvana, beneath a wish-fulfilling tree, stands a golden temple. There is the great Yogapīṭha, with a jeweled throne.

51 On it is always seated the son of the king of Vraja, named Śrī Govinda-deva, the transcendental god of love (*Madana*) in person.

52 There He receives royal service of many wonderful kinds, with divine offerings and divine clothes and ornaments.

53 Thousands of servants serve Him at every moment; even with a thousand mouths that service could not be described.

54 The superintendent of that service is Śrī Haridāsa Paṇḍita, whose fame and virtues are known throughout the world.

55 He is well-mannered, tolerant, peaceful, generous and grave; his words are sweet, his conduct is sweet, and he is deeply steady.

56 He honors everyone and works for everyone's welfare. His heart is free of duplicity, envy and malice.

57 All the fifty general good qualities of Kṛṣṇa reside in his person.

58 “In one who has unalloyed devotion (*akiñcanā bhakti*) for the Lord, all the gods reside with all their good qualities. But how can great qualities exist in one who has no devotion to Hari? Riding the chariot of his mind, he runs outward toward what is unreal.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam 5.18.12)

59 Ananta Ācārya was a disciple of Paṇḍita Gosāñi (Gadādhara Paṇḍita). His body was filled with love for Kṛṣṇa; he was magnanimous and noble in every way.

60 Who can describe his unlimited qualities? His dear disciple is this Haridāsa Paṇḍita.

61 He has supreme faith in Caitanya and Nityānanda and takes supreme delight in Śrī Caitanya's life.

62 He appreciates the good qualities of Vaiṣṇavas and never sees their faults. With body, mind and words he pleases the Vaiṣṇavas.

63 He constantly hears the *Caitanya-maṅgala*, and by his grace all the Vaiṣṇavas hear it too.

64 With his words he lights up the assembly like the full moon, and with the nectar of his qualities he increases the joy of the Vaiṣṇavas.

65 Out of great kindness he ordered me to describe Gaurāṅga's final pastimes.

66 Govinda Gosāñi, a disciple of Kāśīśvara Gosāñi, is a dear servant of Śrī Govinda; there is no one equal to him.

67 Yādavācārya Gosāñi, a companion of Śrī Rūpa, takes great delight in Śrī Caitanya's life.

68 Bhūgarbha Gosāñi, a disciple of Paṇḍita Gosāñi, speaks of nothing but Gaura.

69 His disciples are Caitanya dāsa, the worshiper of Govinda, Mukundānanda Cakravartī and Kṛṣṇadāsa, who is full of love.

70 Śivānanda Cakravartī, a disciple of Ācārya Gosāñi, always holds Śrī Caitanya and Nityānanda in his heart.

71 All the other devotees living in Vṛndāvana also wished to hear the final pastimes.

72 Out of compassion they all gave me the order, and at their word I write, casting off shame.

73 Having received the order of the Vaiṣṇavas, but anxious at heart, I went to Madana-gopāla to ask His permission.

74 After seeing Him, I worshiped His feet. The priest Gosāñi dāsa was serving His feet.

75 When I asked for permission at the Lord's feet, a garland slipped from the Lord's neck and fell.

76 All the Vaiṣṇavas called out “Hari!”, and Gosāñi dāsa brought the garland and placed it around my neck.

77 Receiving the garland as His permission, I was filled with joy, and right there I began this book.

78 It is Madana-mohana who makes me write this book; my writing is like a parrot's recitation.

79 I write whatever Madana-gopāla makes me write, as a magician makes a wooden puppet dance.

80 My family Deity is Madana-mohana, whose servants are Raghunātha, Rūpa and Sanātana.

81 Meditating on the lotus feet of Vṛndāvana dāsa and taking his permission, I write what brings auspiciousness.

82 In Śrī Caitanya's pastimes, Vṛndāvana dāsa is the Vyāsa. Without his mercy they are not revealed to anyone else.

83 I am foolish, low, insignificant and greedy for sense objects; only by the strength of the Vaiṣṇavas' order do I dare so much.

84 This is the power of the feet of Śrī Rūpa and Raghunātha: by remembering them, all one's desires are fulfilled.

85 Praying at the feet of Śrī Rūpa and Raghunātha, I, Kṛṣṇadāsa, tell the *Caitanya-caritāmṛta*.